Organizational Leadership Experience

President – Cybersecurity Association | IEEE | NSBE Leadership

By Joel Tchouke

Throughout my time at Minnesota State University, Mankato, I had the opportunity to hold leadership roles in several student organizations. I served as President of the Cybersecurity Association, Treasurer of the IEEE (Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers) student branch, and I have been an active member of the National Society of Black Engineers (NSBE). These organizations each provided different types of leadership experiences and responsibilities. Together, they allowed me to develop skills in teamwork, organization management, conflict resolution, and strategic planning.

In this reflection, I explore what these experiences were, what they taught me about leadership, and how they will influence the way I approach leadership in the future.

One of the experiences that marked me the most and that I found the most rewarding was serving as President of the Cybersecurity Association. This organization brings together students who are interested in cybersecurity to learn, train, compete, and grow in the field.

My involvement in cybersecurity began when I was a sophomore taking one of the elective courses required for my Computer Engineering major, Information Security (CIS 350). The class focused on protecting systems and information from malicious actors and understanding the principles behind securing digital infrastructures. As the semester progressed, I found myself becoming increasingly fascinated with the subject. Cybersecurity was a field where technical knowledge, critical thinking, and problem-solving intersected in meaningful ways.

During that course, Professor Hart, who supervised the Cybersecurity Association, introduced our class to the organization. He mentioned that elections for a new leadership board were approaching. At the time, my passion for cybersecurity was still very new, but the opportunity to contribute to a community focused on the field immediately captured my interest. Looking back now, deciding to run for president as a relatively new member of the field may seem bold. However, my motivation was simple: I wanted to grow both as an engineer and as a leader.

After an intense voting process among several candidates, I was elected president of the association. I was both excited and aware of the responsibility that came with the role. My goal was not only to promote cybersecurity awareness across campus but also to help our members develop meaningful technical skills and confidence in the field.

One of my first tasks as president was to gather the leadership team and begin planning the academic year. We discussed what types of events we wanted to organize, how we could recruit more members, and how we could build a stronger cybersecurity community on campus. One of the most important goals we identified early on was preparing a team for the Midwest Cyber Collegiate Defense Competition (CCDC), a highly respected cybersecurity competition where universities defend simulated enterprise networks against professional attackers.

However, we quickly encountered a major challenge: our organization had almost no financial resources. Without funding, organizing workshops, training events, or competitions becomes significantly more difficult. At the same time, in order to attract new members, we needed to create engaging activities and opportunities.

Faced with this situation, I realized that leadership in this context could not be authoritarian. The success of the organization would depend on collective effort and shared ideas. I worked closely with my team to brainstorm solutions. Together we decided to reach out to different departments for support and to participate in fundraising opportunities across campus.

One of our earliest fundraising efforts involved volunteering at the university's haunted house event. The task itself was simple, and the reward was modest—our organization would receive one hundred dollars. Yet what stood out to me during that experience was not the amount of money we earned but the willingness of the team to dedicate their time and energy toward a shared goal. Seeing members work together for the benefit of the organization reinforced the idea that leadership is about building commitment and shared purpose within a team.

As we gradually secured small amounts of funding, we began organizing weekly meetings where we discussed cybersecurity topics, practiced technical exercises, and introduced students to concepts such as network defense, system hardening, and incident response. One of our early events was a social cybersecurity challenge where students formed teams and answered technical questions in a competitive format. Seeing students actively engaged and excited about cybersecurity was extremely rewarding and reassured me that the organization was moving in the right direction.

As the year progressed and membership increased, we began forming teams to prepare for the Cyber Collegiate Defense Competition. This was both exciting and intimidating. Many members were new to cybersecurity and had limited hands-on experience with defending real systems.

As the team leader, I often asked myself how to best prepare the group. How could I motivate students who doubted their abilities? How could we compete against universities with far more experience?

Some team members even approached me as the competition date approached to ask if they should withdraw because they felt unprepared. In those moments, I realized that leadership often involves finding the right words to encourage confidence in others. I reassured them that our goal was not simply to win but to learn and grow through the experience. If we committed ourselves to training and teamwork, the results would follow.

We began training several times per week, working together to learn system administration, network monitoring, and incident response techniques. We also reached out to professors and mentors for guidance. The preparation required long hours and significant dedication from everyone involved.

When the day of the competition arrived, the pressure was intense. Universities from across the Midwest were competing, each defending a simulated company infrastructure while professional attackers attempted to compromise their systems. During the competition, our team faced several challenges. Some servers were compromised, tensions rose within the room, and disagreements emerged among team members about how to respond.

At one point, frustration escalated when one member criticized another after a server went down. Another member proudly announced that their system was secure, only for it to be compromised moments later. Situations like these created stress and occasional conflict within the team.

As the team leader, I had to step in to keep the environment constructive and focused. Maintaining a calm atmosphere was essential. A leader must sometimes act as a stabilizing force, ensuring that frustration does not disrupt collaboration. By reminding the team to stay focused and support one another, we were able to continue working effectively despite the pressure.

At the end of the competition, our team placed fifth. For a newly formed team with limited experience, this result was something we were proud of. The following year, after continuing our training and improving our preparation strategies, we achieved third place and came close to qualifying for the national competition. Watching the team grow and improve over time was one of the most satisfying outcomes of my leadership role.

Another important leadership experience during my time at Minnesota State University was serving as Treasurer of the IEEE student branch. IEEE, the Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers, is one of the largest professional engineering organizations in the world, and our student branch focuses on providing technical opportunities, professional development, and networking events for engineering students on campus.

When I decided to run for treasurer, my goal was not simply to manage the organization's finances. I wanted to understand how student organizations operate at a strategic level and how financial resources can be used to create meaningful opportunities for students. As engineers, we often focus on technical challenges, but organizations also require planning, budgeting, coordination, and decision-making to function effectively.

As treasurer, my responsibilities extended far beyond simply recording expenses. I was involved in planning the organization's yearly budget, discussing financial priorities with the leadership team, coordinating fundraising efforts, and ensuring that financial decisions aligned with the goals of the organization. I regularly attended executive meetings where important decisions were made regarding events, partnerships, and long-term initiatives. In these discussions, I often had to provide input about whether certain projects were financially feasible and how resources could be allocated responsibly.

One of the most significant responsibilities during my time as treasurer was my involvement in organizing IEEE's engineering career fair, which represented the organization's largest source of revenue. Planning this event required close collaboration with the university's Career Development Center. Throughout the process, I attended multiple meetings with their staff where we discussed logistics, budgeting, and strategies to ensure the event would be successful for both students and participating companies.

These meetings required me to think beyond simple financial tracking. I had to evaluate how different decisions would affect the organization's budget and the experience of the students attending the event. For example, discussions often included how much we should invest in event logistics, what type of services we could afford, and how the revenue generated from company participation could support future IEEE initiatives. Being part of these conversations helped me understand how financial planning and event organization are closely connected.

Within the IEEE leadership team, the treasurer also plays a key role in helping determine how available funds should be used to support the organization's activities. During our planning meetings, we often discussed how to balance different priorities. Should we invest more resources into technical workshops? Should we allocate funds toward professional development opportunities for students? Could we organize social events that would strengthen the community within the engineering department?

Even decisions that may seem small, such as whether the organization could afford to provide food during events, required careful consideration. Providing food at events often increases student participation, but it must be balanced with the available budget and other financial commitments. In these situations, I had to evaluate our financial situation and help guide discussions about what the organization could realistically support.

One of the most ambitious initiatives we undertook during my time as treasurer was organizing funding to send fifteen students to the IEEE Rising Stars conference. This professional conference provides students with opportunities to network with engineers, researchers, and companies from across the country. However, funding travel, lodging, and registration for such a large group required extensive planning.

To make this possible, I worked closely with the IEEE president and faculty advisors to explore multiple funding opportunities. We prepared proposals for IEEE Region 4 support, outlining the educational benefits of the trip and providing detailed expense breakdowns. At the same time, we organized local fundraising initiatives, including partnerships with local businesses such as a Chipotle fundraiser where a portion of customer purchases supported our organization.

Managing these initiatives required persistence and careful coordination. Every expense had to be tracked, every funding opportunity had to be documented, and every financial decision needed to align with the organization's long-term goals.

Through these experiences, I came to realize that financial leadership within an organization is not simply about managing numbers. It is about understanding how resources can be used to create opportunities, support student development, and strengthen the community around the organization. Serving as IEEE treasurer allowed me to see the operational side of leadership and gave me a deeper appreciation for the planning and collaboration required to make large initiatives successful.

In addition to my leadership roles in technical organizations, I have also been an active member of the National Society of Black Engineers (NSBE). NSBE plays an important role in supporting engineering students through mentorship, professional development, and community building.

Being part of NSBE allowed me to connect with a network of students who share similar academic ambitions and challenges. Engineering programs can often be demanding, and organizations like NSBE create spaces where students can support one another academically and professionally.

One opportunity I am particularly excited about is attending the 2026 NSBE Annual Convention in Baltimore. This convention brings together thousands of engineering students, professionals, and companies from across the country. Events like this provide students with opportunities to network with industry leaders, attend technical workshops, and explore potential career paths.

Beyond the professional opportunities, NSBE reinforced an important aspect of leadership: the value of community. Leadership is not only about managing teams or organizing events, but also about creating environments where individuals feel supported and encouraged to succeed. Through NSBE, I saw how mentorship and representation can motivate students to pursue ambitious goals within engineering and beyond.

Reflecting on these leadership experiences, I realized that organizational leadership is fundamentally about people. Technical knowledge and planning are important, but the ability to motivate, support, and guide a team is what ultimately determines success.

Leading the Cybersecurity Association taught me how to build a team from the ground up and how to inspire confidence in individuals who may doubt their abilities. Serving as IEEE treasurer taught me discipline, financial responsibility, and the importance of strategic planning. Being involved in NSBE reinforced the value of community and mentorship.

Across all of these experiences, one lesson became clear: leadership is not about controlling every aspect of an organization. Instead, it is about empowering others, creating opportunities for growth, and fostering collaboration.

Looking ahead, the leadership skills I developed through these organizations will continue to influence how I approach teamwork and responsibility in my professional career. As an engineer, I will often work in multidisciplinary teams where communication, collaboration, and leadership are essential.

The experiences I gained through student organizations showed me that leadership does not require a formal title. Leadership can take the form of encouraging teammates during difficult moments, organizing resources to achieve a goal, or simply creating an environment where others feel confident contributing their ideas.

Ultimately, these organizational experiences helped shape my understanding of leadership as a continuous process of learning, collaboration, and service. Whether in engineering teams, research environments, or professional organizations, I hope to carry these lessons forward and continue developing as a leader who supports and empowers others.